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My cousin in Egypt sent me the clip before anyone here did. “Is this guy for real?” he wrote.

It was the now-viral moment from Tucker Carlson's nearly three-hour interview with Mike Huckabee, the United States ambassador to Israel. Carlson, trying to pin down what Huckabee means when he calls himself a “Christian Zionist,” asks him to define it plainly. Christians must believe, Huckabee presses, that the Jewish people have a right to a homeland because the Bible says so. Carlson asks for further clarification. He quotes the passage verbatim—God promising land stretching “from the Nile to the Euphrates”—and asks the obvious follow-up: Does that mean Israel has a divine claim to what is, functionally, all of the Middle East?

Huckabee puts it this way: “It would be fine if they took it all.”

That's where the viral clip ends. The full answer contains a hedge, where Huckabee insists it's an irrelevant hypothetical: “I think you're missing something, because they're not asking to go back and take all of that.” Later, he says he's “not sure” it would be OK for Israel to attempt to conquer all of that land.

But even a hypothetical mass annexation has a way of setting off a frenzy.

In Cairo, where my cousin lives, it landed differently than it might elsewhere. The Nile runs through the middle of Egypt, feeding nearly every one of its 100 million people. It's in the country's national anthem. [In the best love songs](#). A statue of the beloved [Umm Kulthum](#) looks out over it. The [pyramids rise](#) not far from its banks. Without the Nile, there isn't an Egypt. And for a powerful American diplomat to casually offer it up—citing the Bible—doesn't read like edgy podcast banter. It's a major international provocation.

Within hours, officials across the region were issuing statements, and Saudi Arabia led a [sharp rebuke](#), condemning any suggestion of territorial expansion.

“[Greater Israel](#),” as it's often called by the most [maximalist voices](#) in Israeli politics, would also include Jordan, Syria, Iraq, Lebanon, Saudi Arabia, and more. Egypt fought multiple wars with Israel before signing a peace treaty in 1979. When my cousin heard “Nile to the Euphrates,” he wondered if this could be the moment that drives Egypt to finally sour on its neighbor to the north.

My cousin was also curious how Americans were reacting. I told him most probably hadn't seen it. And if they had, it was quickly overshadowed by something else in our breakneck news cycle, like FBI director [Kash Patel chugging beer](#) with the gold medal-winning men's hockey team.

By the next morning, I had three more clips waiting in my WhatsApp. One showed Carlson grilling Huckabee about Palestinian Christians and asking why the U.S. isn't doing more to protect them. Another had Carlson pushing on the fact that more than 200 journalists have been killed in Gaza. Huckabee's answers were defensive and flippant.

The third clip stopped me cold. Carlson asks Huckabee: If the claim is that the land belongs to the

descendants of Abraham, and that includes secular Jews who identify ethnically but not religiously, as well as Jewish converts, then how could those descendants not include Palestinians with genetic ancestry tied to the land?

“How do we know that Bibi, specifically Bibi’s ancestors, ever lived here?” Carlson asked. “Maybe I could ask you, how do we know they didn’t?” Huckabee shot back. Carlson dropped the smile. “It’s on the basis of the claim that they did that all kinds of things happen. People are displaced. There’s a money flow. I mean, it’s a big question. A lot hangs on this. It’s not some theoretical thing. It’s like, *No, no, we have a right to be here because my ancestors were here*. OK, how do we know they were here?”

Carlson’s phrasing here isn’t the clearest, but it’s easy enough to discern what he’s asking: Some Israeli politicians—as well as their supporters—justify the state’s actions based on the idea that they are reclaiming their ancestral homeland. This isn’t the only line of argument that Israeli officials use to support their nation’s establishment and actions, but it’s a prominent one. Given that this line of reasoning contributes to massive consequences for millions of people, how do we decide who exactly gets to live there? And how do we decide who doesn’t?

Huckabee, however, appeared dumbfounded: “I’m totally unable to process what you’re trying to get at.”

That line felt much more consequential to me than the line about the rivers. Here was the American ambassador being asked to explain the foundation for policies that have immiserated millions. But he waved off the premise as incomprehensible—not just because he didn’t have an answer, but because he didn’t seem to think the question deserved one.

I couldn’t help myself. I watched the entire interview. Nearly three hours, the length of a feature film, shot in a sterile diplomatic holding area at Ben Gurion Airport. Carlson spends almost half an hour explaining why they’re filming there—he says Israeli officials had accused him of antisemitism, even of being a Nazi, and he didn’t feel safe traveling with official escorts. He sounds paranoid, slightly theatrical. It’s very Tucker.

To be clear, Tucker’s critiques of Israeli policy are mixed with a long history of racism. That includes his embrace of the [“Great Replacement Theory”](#) and saying things like [Iraqis are “semiliterate primitive monkeys.”](#) And so I’m not here to lionize Carlson, even if he has recently tried to become [some sort of champion of the oppressed](#). And indeed, I wish his compassion for Palestinians extended to [children suffering in Immigration and Customs Enforcement facilities](#) and at the [southern U.S. border](#).

But, in this interview, it’s telling that Huckabee can get away with deeply anti-Arab racism while holding such a prominent position in the U.S. government.

When the interview begins in earnest, the choreography is familiar. Carlson disarms his guest with niceties. He apologizes for mocking “Christian Zionism” online. Huckabee seems charmed, but he’s playing too. At moments I forgot I was watching a U.S. ambassador and felt like I was watching a podcast bro talking about geopolitics between ads. And yet, it quickly becomes surreal. This is not some YouTube debate between influencers. This is the American ambassador to Israel explaining how his religious beliefs are the basis for how he understands his role in the Middle East.

The tone is casual. Huckabee leans back. Carlson is [squinting](#) as he asks his questions in a way

that sounds naive and lets Huckabee fill the space. It's a master class in playing dumb to get someone to explain their untellable positions. Both are pretending to be delighted and easily confused.

About 40 minutes in, I could hardly take it anymore. Carlson keeps asking definitional questions. Which countries exactly have a "right to exist"? What are Israel's borders? Are all lives equal? Huckabee pleads confusion constantly.

There comes a point where Huckabee handwaves the tens of thousands of children killed by Israeli forces in Gaza, urging Carlson to consider that a number of them are legitimate military targets. Carlson takes a position that (if applied to all parties involved) is morally unassailable: "I'm against killing children. Period."

Here the choreography flips. Huckabee suddenly becomes incapable of backing down. "You know why they got killed? Because Hamas would gather up the children and put them in the targets."

It's insane that an American diplomat would say this out loud. Yes, there are documented findings that [Hamas operates within civilian infrastructure](#). There are also countless reports from international doctors who say they treated children with [deliberately inflicted gunshot wounds](#). Israel Defense Forces sieges on hospitals resulted in the [death of premature babies](#). Israeli journalists have [published testimonies](#) from soldiers describing permissive rules of engagement in places like the Netzarim Corridor that were deemed a "kill zone," an invisible boundary where anyone who crossed an unofficial line was shot, including children.

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In one incident described in the report, soldiers opened fire on a figure later identified as a 16-year-old boy. A battalion commander later congratulated the unit for killing a terrorist. When someone objected, the commander responded: "Anyone crossing the line is a terrorist, no exceptions, no civilians. Everyone's a terrorist."

In the interview, Huckabee cites no investigation. No military briefing. No specific case. He presents

the broad rhetorical image as the explanation for why [an extraordinary number of children have been killed in Gaza](#). Instead, he converts thousands of dead children into a single image: militants herding them into missile paths.

This is hard to sit through for me, a father to two Arab toddlers. I would hope it would be hard for you—whoever you are—to sit through too.

I found myself wishing Carlson had gone further. There are a host of ways to dismantle Huckabee's argument, and [it's important to do so](#). Thousands of children, small humans entirely innocent of Hamas' Oct. 7 atrocities, are dead. They are dead due to decisions made by Israel's government and military. And they are dead due to the United States' bipartisan [participation in Israel's actions](#).

Wars produce cruelty that falls hardest on those with the least power. Which is why, when someone powerful, say a U.S. ambassador, flippantly suggests it "would be fine" for any country to massively expand—an expansion that could not happen without catastrophic warfare—it's beyond alarming.

My cousin in Egypt wanted to know if this Huckabee guy was for real. It's a complicated question. As Huckabee noted, there's no evidence that Israel is preparing an expansionist push "from the Nile to the Euphrates." But Israel has already annexed Syria's Golan Heights, a move most of the international community considers illegal. And in the West Bank, settlement expansion continues and complete annexation is openly advocated for by top members of Israel's current government. Maximalist rhetoric from Huckabee—who is, again, a U.S. ambassador—[cosigns those extreme aims](#), and he cannot even bring himself to use words like occupation, settlement, or even West Bank. And so, after three hours, I have a sad answer for my cousins.

In any sane world, they (and the rest of the world) could safely ignore Huckabee. In the world we live in, they sadly can't.

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